BOOK CLUB EXPRESS

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My Friends: A Novel
by Fredrik Backman

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Discussion Questions

1. *My Friends* deals intimately with themes of friendship and loyalty, uniting characters who seem, from the outside, to be more different than alike. What is it that brings them together, and what does that say to you about the enduring power of human connection?

2. Was there a particular character you identified with more than the others? Why?

3. The artist's painting of the sea plays a pivotal role in the book, as it inspired the group of friends --- and later Louisa --- toward a common goal. Does art play a different role in the lives of young people than it does in adults? Do you think the painting's significance changes as the friends grow older?

4. What do you think the pier in the painting might symbolize?

5. The setting of the story, a town by the sea, influences the atmosphere and character dynamics. How did the setting impact your experience of reading the book?

6. While being at times delightfully funny and lighthearted, *My Friends* also explores serious topics of loss, grief and trauma. How did these topics, present from the very beginning, change your perspective of the individual characters as you got to know them?

7. In Chapter 28, Louisa says that her friend, Fish, read in a book that in Heaven you could choose a moment in life when you felt really good, and then you got to feel like that for all eternity. What would that moment be for you, and what does it say about Fish and Louisa that they are entranced by this idea?

8. Joar's character is perhaps the one that changes the most over the course of the book. Were you surprised to meet him in the latter half of the book? Consider the ways he was different and the ways he was the same.

9. Family dynamics and upbringing greatly influence the personalities, values and choices of Ted, Joar, Ali and the artist. Discuss the role of inherited trauma in the lives of these characters. What do they gain and/or lose because of these legacies?

10. The themes of redemption and second chances are present throughout the book. How do these second chances ultimately play out, and how do they help to tie up the narrative and character arcs in the book?

11. Fredrik Backman often uses humor and wit to navigate through darker moments in his novels. Discuss some of your favorite moments of humor in *My Friends*. How did they impact your reading experience?

12. Ted, Joar, Ali and the artist could be considered a "chosen family." How does the concept of home feature throughout the book? Do you think those ideas change as we get older?

13. In chapter 7, the artist thinks to himself, “You have to take [life] for granted.... That’s the only courageous thing a person can do.” What do you imagine he means by this?

14. When the artist is telling Ted about his meeting with Louisa in the alley, he says, “She’s one of us!” In what ways is Louisa similar to the artist and his group of childhood friends?

From: https://www.readinggroupguides.com/reviews/my-friends-by-fredrik-backman/guide

Author Interview

BOOKSELLING THIS WEEK: Would you tell us a little about developing this novel? Where did the inspiration for this story come from?

FREDRIK BACKMAN: I wish I had a better answer for this question, but I very rarely know how anything works or comes from. Every book is just a long, chaotic process of me sitting alone in a room, arguing loudly with people I have made up.

In this case, it started with me writing a first draft that had about 82 parallel storylines and somewhere around 9,000 characters. Everyone I showed it to said, "Oh…this is…interesting," in that tone of voice you would have after trying the cooking of someone who is clearly drunk.

My wife finally sat me down and said: "It's really dark, Fredrik. Because you're in a dark place right now. It's okay. But you need to find some hope in this story, some redemption, not just for the book but for you."

I didn't know it was that obvious, but I had been struggling really badly with my confidence as a writer, and for about two years I really considered retiring from book publishing altogether. Then I showed the draft to two other writers, and one of them said, "I really loved the story about the kids on the pier. I got angry every time you left them to go talk about someone else." And the other one said, "The story about the kids on that pier made me really think about how to be a better father."

So, I took all that, and I started from the beginning with the kids on the pier. I thought: If this is the last book I ever write, who would I want it to be for? And then I wrote the dedication page: "To anyone who is young and wants to create something. Do it." The entire story came out of that.

BTW: I love the dedication. That desire to create something is such a big part of this book. Do you want to tell us a little more about that? What else do you hope readers take away from this story?

FB: I hope you just take that. If you do, that's enough.

Whatever it is you want to create that you for whatever reason are afraid of pursuing, because you think you're not good enough or not smart enough or whatever it is. You just have to go, try, fail, try again. "Fail better," like Samuel Beckett put it.

Not for success or fame or fortune or any of that bullshit. Just for you.

BTW: My Friends is full of both beautiful moments and heartbreaking ones. It also moves between timelines, following both Louisa and the subjects of her favorite painting some decades earlier. What was the most challenging part of creating this story?

FB: There's always a technical part and an emotional part to a novel. Technically, the biggest challenge was tempo and movement and language. How do I move this story forward? For how long can I keep your attention? What is every character's distinct voice? Emotionally, the biggest challenge by far was the fact that so much of the people in this book comes from people I grew up with — some of whom I've lost along the way. I had a lot of days talking to ghosts.

BTW: My Friends is in part about how deeply you can be affected by a piece of art, like Louisa and The One of the Sea. Has a piece of art had a similar effect on you? Which one?

FB: The thing is, I didn't know a lot about art growing up. But my wife loves art. She studied art history, so wherever we travel with our kids, she'll take us to some awesome museum. Some of my fondest travel memories with the family are from places like the Picasso Museum in Málaga, or the Warhol Museum in Pittsburgh. We saw a VR exhibition of the works of Van Gogh in Copenhagen last summer, and my kids talked about The Starry Night for an entire dinner afterwards. That's everything to me.

In the book, I wrote this line where a nurse turns to a world-famous artist and says: "My husband loved your work. We saw some of your paintings in a gallery once. I loved the way he looked when he looked at them."

That's from the way I feel about going to museums with my wife. I love how much she loves things.

BTW: Would you tell us a bit about the role of books and indie bookstores in your life?

FB: When writing My Friends — when I was really stuck and struggling with my confidence — I went with my 12-year-old daughter to The English Bookshop in Stockholm. It was a Saturday, it was freezing cold outside, and the place was absolutely PACKED with teenagers.

They were all insanely passionate about books I'd never heard about. My daughter went on and on about book genres I didn't even know existed. Then all of a sudden, one young woman asked a staff member, "Do you have White Nights by Dostoevsky?"

I remember standing there in this small indie bookshop just thinking, "Whoever is saying young people don't read anymore is out of their goddamn minds."

Whenever I feel lost in the industry part of the book industry, I think about that Saturday. The young people are taking everything over now, and it's going to be great.

From: https://www.bookweb.org/news/qa-fredrik-backman-author-may-indie-next-list-top-pick-%E2%80%9Cmy-friends%E2%80%9D-1631831

Author Biography

Fredrik Backman is the #1 New York Times bestselling author of A Man Called Ove, My Grandmother Asked Me to Tell You She's Sorry, Britt-Marie Was Here, Beartown, Us Against You, Anxious People, The Winners, and My Friends, as well as two novellas and one work of nonfiction. His books are published in more than forty countries. He lives in Stockholm, Sweden, with his wife and two children.

From: https://www.simonandschuster.com/p/fredrik-backman#about

Reviews

Fredrik Backman is the New York Times bestselling author of many novels including Anxious People and A Man Called Ove. His writing is lovingly detailed, and his stories have been described as warmhearted, charming, wise, funny, and powerful. As a reader, I've loved how Backman's stories capture one from the very first page. I've long admired the way his stories are written: pages filled with compassionate characters, wonderful details, and beautiful descriptions. That's why I was so thrilled to read his latest novel, My Friends.

The story of My Friends follows the lives of four friends during one particular summer and how from that one summer a famous painting was created which features these four friends. The story also follows an eighteen-year-old girl named Louisa. To tell the story of Louisa and the four friends in the painting the chapters in My Friends alternate between the present and the past. The present story belongs to Louisa while the past story (taking place twenty-five years earlier) belongs to teenagers Joar, Ted, Ali, and the artist (who painted the famous painting).

The novels of Fredrik Backman feature themes of loss, change, sadness, grief, the power of friendship and how life can be complicated and at times messy, but there are also themes of joy, hope, and second chances. My Friends carries on some of these themes through the character of Louisa, who is grieving the loss of her best friend. Louisa finds her only comfort in the form of a picture postcard with a painting printed on it; a postcard she took from one of the many foster homes she lived in. It "was the first thing Louisa ever stole" and "the first really beautiful thing she ever touched." The power of friendship, change, and hope features prominently in the story of the four friends. Especially touching is the way the friends leave each other at the end of the long summer days they spend together. They simply say to each other "Tomorrow." To them "Tomorrow" is a promise, a strength they offer each other to get through the evenings—because though their days are filled with sunshine and hanging out and laughing together at a pier in their seaside hometown, their evenings are filled with abuse, anger, frustration and pain. The novel takes an in-depth look at friendship and what it means to be a friend, to be so close and to know each other so well—to have a bond so deep, that it can create an unforgettable and cherished work of art, capturing one moment in time, that will affect the life of a young woman twenty-five years in the future.

Backman's words take us into the world of these four friends, so you can smell the sea air, hear the laughter, and experience the joy of being young and reckless. His words help us to see the smallness of their world and the frustration of their home lives. At the same time, we can feel the grief Louisa experiences and the way she is a survivor. I enjoyed the time spent with the four friends and Louisa, and the way the novel really hits its stride when the story of Louisa and the four friends intertwines when two characters meet and take a cross-country journey.

There is much in My Friends that fans of Backman and those new to his novels will love. It's a tender heartwarming novel exploring the challenges and joys of life itself, of loving and trusting others, of unexpected change and unexpected hope.

From: https://chireviewofbooks.com/2025/05/06/exploring-the-challenges-and-joys-of-life-trust-and-friendship-in-fredrik-backmans-my-friends/

Read-Alikes

The Borrowed Life of Frederick Fife by Anna Johnston

Frederick Fife was born with an extra helping of kindness in his heart. If he borrowed your car, he'd return it washed with a full tank of gas. The problem is there's nobody left in Fred's life to borrow from. At eighty-two, he's desperately lonely, broke, and on the brink of homelessness. Fred's luck changes when, in a bizarre case of mistaken identity, he takes the place of Bernard Greer at the local nursing home. Now he has a roof over his head, three meals a day, and, most importantly, the chance to be part of a family again. All he has to do is hope that his poker face is in better shape than his prostate and that his look-alike never turns up. As Fred navigates life in Bernard's shoes, he learns about the man's past and what it might take to return a life in better condition than he found it.

The Road to Tender Hearts by Annie Hartnett

At sixty-three years old, million-dollar lottery winner PJ Halliday would be the luckiest man in Pondville, Massachusetts, if it weren't for the tragedies of his life: the sudden death of his eldest daughter and the way his marriage fell apart after that. Since then, PJ spends both his money and his time at the bar, and he probably doesn't have much time left--he's had three heart attacks already. But when PJ reads the obituary of his old romantic rival, he realizes his high school sweetheart, Michelle Cobb, is finally single again. Filled with a new enthusiasm for life, PJ decides he's going to drive across the country to the Tender Hearts Retirement Community in Arizona to win Michelle back. Before PJ can hit the road, tragedy strikes Pondville, leaving PJ the sudden guardian of his estranged brother's grandchildren. Anyone else would be deterred from the planned trip, but PJ figures the orphaned kids might benefit from getting out of town. PJ also thinks he can ask Sophie, his adult daughter who's adrift in her twenties, to come along to babysit. And there's one more surprise addition to the roster: Pancakes, a former nursing home therapy cat with a knack of predicting death, who recently turned up outside PJ's home. This could be the second chance PJ has long hoped for--a fresh shot at love and parenting--but does he have the strength to do both those things again? It's very possible his heart can't take it.